

— A UBNI MISSION RESOURCE — MUNICIPAL · REGIONAL · NATIONAL

A Sovereign Food System

DRAFT: A BODY OF WORK BUILT FOR, AND DEVELOPING ON THE GROUND IN, SWEDEN

A food system doesn't become resilient through better intentions. It becomes resilient when the money running through it — who creates it, who gets it first, how it circulates, how it's withdrawn — is redesigned to reward nourishment, preparedness and local value instead of cheap calories and leakage. This is a portfolio of economic and monetary instruments for doing exactly that, from a municipal kitchen contract to a central bank's digital currency — grounded in specific Swedish institutions, law and live pilots, not a generic model. But the pressures it responds to aren't unique to Sweden, and an incredible amount of what's here — the instruments, the sequencing, the reasoning — carries directly into other contexts, the UK included.

START WITH THE DIAGNOSIS ↓

JUMP TO LOCAL TOOLS ↗

SCOPE — built for, and being tested within, Swedish municipal, regional and national institutions · TRANSFERABILITY — the specific mechanisms are Swedish, but the logic behind them travels well — including to contexts like the UK · LOGIC — each instrument stands alone, but the portfolio compounds when instruments are combined and sequenced · PRIMARY ENTRY POINT — municipalities, who hold the most levers closest to the food system

Adapted from *A Sovereign Food System*, written by Samuel Färdow Kazen (Positiva Pengar), Jessica Johansson and Gino Carciola (MiljöMatematik Malmö), and Aleksander Nowak (Dark Matter Labs), as part of the Universal Basic Nutrient Income (UBNI) mission — a collaboration with RISE Research Institutes of Sweden and Krinova, supported by Vinnova.

— WHO THIS IS FOR

Four ways in

MUNICIPAL OFFICIAL

Public meals, procurement, land, preparedness

This maps the economic tools already inside your mandate, and shows how to combine them into a local food transition strategy.

REGIONAL AUTHORITY

Public health, healthcare financing, infrastructure

Shows how food-system investment at regional level can cut healthcare costs, build resilience, and coordinate what municipalities are already doing.

NATIONAL POLICYMAKER

Central bank, treasury, parliament

Proposes the infrastructure — frameworks, fiscal instruments, investment banks and monetary tools — that make local and regional action scale coherently.

PRODUCER & CIVIL SOCIETY

Farms, cooperatives, food hubs, investors

Maps the policy environment that could support your work, and the economic circuits you could realistically become part of.

— THE DIAGNOSIS

A mispriced economy, not a failing one

Food's real costs — to public health, ecosystems, rural economies and future resilience — almost never show up at the point of purchase. That single fact drives five distinct, compounding failures.

IN PLAIN TERMS

The food that's worst for us and the planet is often the cheapest, because nobody has to pay its real costs upfront. Fixing that price signal is the lever everything else in this page pulls on.

01

Preparedness & Resilience

Food production depends heavily on imported fertiliser, feed and fuel, while retail is concentrated in a handful of dominant chains — a system

02

Environmental Degradation

Emissions, biodiversity loss, soil depletion and nutrient pollution carry no price at the point of purchase, so the food doing the most damage often remains the cheapest on the shelf.

optimised for efficiency in calm conditions and fragile under shock.

03

Healthcare Costs

Unhealthy diets are cheap and convenient by design, while preventive nutrition remains structurally underfunded — diet-related disease becomes one of the largest, most preventable cost lines in the welfare system.

04

Inequality

Healthy, sustainable food is structurally more expensive and harder to access, so the diets most likely to protect long-term health are the ones lowest-income households can least afford.

05

Rural Economic Stagnation

Value is extracted from food-producing regions rather than retained and recirculated locally — leaving rural places less economically viable and harder to sustain for the next generation.

— THE VISION

Five goals for 2040

A sovereign food system means moving from “enough calories” to a society genuinely able to provide nutritious, culturally meaningful food within planetary boundaries — even during crisis.

I

Prepared & resilient

Less dependent on imported inputs, healthier soils, able to withstand shocks and global disruption.

II

Environmentally sustainable

Agroecological and regenerative production, shorter supply chains, genuinely circular systems.

III

Healthy & nourishing

IV

Equitable & fair

Plant-forward, minimally processed diets that are the convenient and affordable default, not the exception.

Fair compensation for producers, less power concentration in the value chain, food as a guaranteed social right.

V

Economically revitalising

Local value retained and recirculated, rural municipalities strong enough to attract the next generation.

2040

Read the full scenario



MUNICIPAL LEVEL – THE PRIMARY ENTRY POINT

Fourteen local instruments

Municipalities hold the most practical, immediately actionable levers — public meals, procurement, land, waste streams, social programmes and preparedness responsibilities, combined with local knowledge. Expand any instrument below for what it does and a real example of it working.

Municipal Money & currency design Regional National

4.1

Innovative Public Procurement



4.2

A Living Preparedness Storage



4.3

Food as an Employee Benefit



4.4

Food as Livelihood Support



4.5	Food for Work	+
4.6	Food as Medicine (municipal)	+
4.7	Protect & Secure Farmland	+
4.8	Land Conversion: Perennial Systems	+
4.9	Local Carbon Credits & Transition Income	+
4.10	Municipal Cows & Pigs as a Service	+
4.11	Part-Time Growers & Civic Production	+
4.12	Large-Scale Composting & Soil Inputs	+
4.13	Local Fund for Nature-Based Solutions	+
4.14	De-Risked Transitional Ownership	+

— REDESIGNING MONEY ITSELF

What a local currency is actually for

A municipal complementary currency isn't a gimmick — it's one of the fastest, cheapest ways to change behaviour when budgets and legal room are both tight. It shows up as an option throughout the local instruments above.

IN PLAIN TERMS

A council can create its own local money, spendable mainly with local producers and shops, and use it to top up wages, pay part of a supplier contract, or reward organic and low-carbon deliveries — all without breaking EU competition rules.

5.2 What a Local Currency Actually Does



5.3 Local Currency in Public Procurement



5.2b Designing the Currency



— REGIONAL LEVEL

Where healthcare becomes the engine

Regions carry the healthcare cost of diet-related disease directly — which makes them the natural home for financing prevention as infrastructure, not just treatment.

6.1 Food as Medicine (regional)



— NATIONAL LEVEL

Nine national instruments

The role of the state is to provide the mandate, financing instruments, legal clarity and coordination that let local and regional actors act at sufficient scale — not to run the food system from the centre.

7.1	A National Food Sovereignty Framework	+
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7.2	A National NutrientBank & Food Eligibility Standard	+
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7.3	A National UBNI	+
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7.4	A National Fresh Food Subsidy (<i>Friskmatsbidrag</i>)	+
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7.5	True Cost Pricing & Fiscal Reform	+
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7.6	A National Food-System Investment Bank	+
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7.7	A National Support System for Preparedness Storage	+
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7.8	National Land, Soil & Water Sovereignty Programme	+
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7.9	A National Programme for Food Work & Civic Production	+
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— SOVEREIGN MONEY, SOVEREIGN FOOD

Why the monetary system itself is the constraint

None of the above is impossible under the current monetary architecture. It's just harder, more expensive, and more dependent on private credit conditions than it needs to be.

IN PLAIN TERMS

Right now, new money mostly comes from private bank loans chasing safe, easily-resellable assets — not from investing in soil, food storage or rural jobs. Fixing that means changing how money itself gets created, not just spending more of it.

THE BARRIERS

A	Money created for private profit, not public value	+
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B	Asset inflation over productive investment	+
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C	The monetary centre–periphery problem	+
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D	How risk regulation underfinances the transition	+
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E	Debt dependence and financial fragility	+
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F	Payment-system fragility	+
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G	Blunt side effects of interest-rate policy	+
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THE TOOLS

A	Sovereign money: public control over creation	+
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B	Currency sovereignty as policy space	+
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C

A public digital currency as infrastructure

+

D

Monetary tools beyond the interest rate

+

— IMPLEMENTATION

Four expanding circles

None of this depends on one national reform or every actor moving at once. It starts with existing municipal mandates, and widens as capacity, evidence and political support build.

PHASE 1

Most vulnerable

People in food poverty, welfare recipients

Food as livelihood support, food vouchers, nutrient credits, targeted UBNI pilots, community kitchens.

PHASE 2

Risk groups

People with diet-related disease, elderly people, children

Food as Medicine, school-food transformation, elderly-care nutrition, regional health impact bonds.

PHASE 3

Broader population

Everyone

Employee food benefits, fresh food subsidies, local currencies, procurement reform, food-literacy work.

PHASE 4

Whole system

Producers, municipalities, the national economy

Land conversion, national eligibility standards, the investment bank, sovereign monetary infrastructure.

A Sovereign Food System

A portfolio of economic and monetary instruments for food-system transformation – municipal, regional, national and monetary. Each instrument can stand on its own; the effect compounds when they're combined and sequenced together.

Draft: unpublished work from our work in Sweden.
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A SOVEREIGN FOOD SYSTEM – WORKING PORTFOLIO